

Three visual criteria. Generating an MID relative risk threshold

Core GRADE users will, when outcomes are binary, typically judge inconsistency by examining forest plots presenting relative risks and considering the similarity of point estimates and the extent to which confidence intervals overlap. When the threshold is the MID, however, it is absolute rather than relative differences that determine whether inconsistency is problematic. Making the judgement about problematic inconsistency therefore requires converting the relative to an absolute effect.

The hypothetical example in Figure 3 in the body of the paper addresses this issue. We present how authors might have proceeded. Let us say the outcome in Figure 3 is mortality and the MID in mortality is 10 in 1,000 or 1%. Let us further say that the baseline risk of dying is 7%. Authors will then ask the question of what relative risk reduction corresponds to the 1% absolute MID.

As it turns out, the answer to that question is a 15% relative risk reduction, as illustrated in the following:

The formula for calculation the relative risk reduction that corresponds to the absolute MID is: Absolute MID / baseline risk

Using this formula in the above situation, the relative risk reduction corresponding to MID is as follows: $1\% / 7\% = 0.14$ or 14% or approximately 15%.

The relative effect that corresponds to MID can be calculated as:

$$1 - \text{relative risk reduction} = 1 - 0.15 = 0.85$$

Having decided, as described, on the relative effect that corresponds to MID one can include a vertical line – as in Figure 2 - vividly illustrating the relative effect that corresponds to the absolute MID.